Saturday Night/Sunday Morning

By Katori Hall

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Suggested Roles: *Actress 1: Gladys, Taffy*
Actress 2: Leanne, Mabel, Miss Mary and Radio

Gladys: From Birmingham, Alabama . . . Homely, slightly ugly even, but expertly put together. A churchgoing girl in her early 20s – an aspiring writer.
Miss Mary: 30 going on 60. The owner of the beauty shop/boarding house. A widow who lost her husband during WWII.
Leanne: Early 20s – A beauty queen from Texas. Depressed since she hasn't heard from her beau, Bobby, who is fighting overseas.
Taffy: Late Teens – Mabel's younger sister – an ugly duckling and a bit socially inept
Mabel: Early 20s – a loose, wild woman searching for adventure. Taffy's older sister

GLADYS: Is Miss Mary 'round? Folk say she rentin' out rooms to young girls.

MISS MARY: Ain't no mo' room up in here. Only bed open is a bed in my room and I don't share.

GLADYS: Well . . . I'm justa needin' a room to board up in for a while. Thass all. How much you rentin' rooms fu'?

MISS MARY: If I had one to rentcha it'd be a dollar a week. If this was a brothel y'all wouldn't have to pay nothin', but it ain't, though **some** folk wanna treat it as such . . . I fount a tourser sock in ya'll room and don't nobody wear trouser socks 'round here. Last time I checked womens was wearin' nylons.

GLADYS: I could do som work 'round here. I was a secretary in a church so I knows typewritin' like the back of my hand.

MISS MARY: If you got fingers that can shampoo you some hair I'm all for it. Let me see them hands. I needs 'em quick and nimble. *(Miss Mary goes to pull off*

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Gladys's gloves. She snatches her hands back.)

GLADYS: Let me show ya how quick and nimble I can be. *(She pulls out a typewriter from her suitcase, plunks it down and swiftly puts in a piece of paper. She types out a paragraph)*

MISS MARY: I like them fingahs. I bet you could scratch some dandruff out folk heads. But . . . it still ain't no room up in here.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Set in a Memphis beauty shop/boarding house during the final days of WWII,*
ACTRESS 2: *a group of African American women draw strength from each other as they wait for the war to come to an end.*
TOGETHER: *Saturday Night / Sunday Morning by Katori Hall.*

LEANNE: *Leanne sashays slowly over to Gladys* I'm Leanne. . . I like yo' style. Memphis women ain't dressin' like that. That hat. Them ribbons. Them gloves . . . Cute. Remind me of Texas. You cute. (to Miss Mary) She can stay in my room. It's fit for a queen, but it can hold two. Nice to meet you, honey bun.

TAFFY: She got a curse on her.

MISS MARY: Y'all be in a bad mood, too, yo' maine say he gone do somethin' and he don't do it.

TAFFY: How he gone write letters and shoot people at the same time? The womens these days.

LEANNE: *(ignoring her)* Why mens can go away, but they memory just stay wit' ya? Sometime it's better when they gone than when they here. *(she bursts into tears)*

GLADYS: Her, here, lady. You know if you pray, God'll take all the pain away.

LEANNE: I done tried, tried everything! Oh, I just miss him so. I remember how he smelled, his touch. You know how a person just haunt yo' body. . .

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GLADYS: Did he die?

LEANNE: Unh, unh! Don't say that. Don't you ever say that about my baby Bobby!! When I go outside every maine I see look exactly like him.

GLADYS: You just havin' visions. Thems can be taken care of wit' a lil' prayer.

LEANNE: Honeycomb, I don't know how to pray *(Beat)* You got a lot to learn. *(Leanne exits)*

GLADYS: She gone get sick carryin' that cup of tears in her throat for so long.

TAFFY: Where does you get all them sayins? Fu' as long I been alive I ain't never heard colored fold talk the way you talk.

MABEL: Yeah, they be soundin' . . . special. Who talk like that?

GLADYS: *(defensive)* Writers. Actually, I thought maybe . . . I could . . . When I was down home, I say this ad in the paper. (She pulls out a yellowed, wrinkled newspaper from her Bible and hands it to the girls. They satre at it. Then her. They can't read) Oh . . . It says the Chicago Defender's lookin' for them a new reporter . . . I always wrote my own stories. Made 'em up.

MABEL: *(Sharp gasp)* Huh! That's it! That's it! Why didn't I thank of this earlier. We been needin' to get old beauty queen out that salty mood . . . You could help us – **all** of us – out.

GLADYS: By doin' what?

MABEL: By writin'. To Leanne. Like you Bobby. We get Gladys to write like she Bobby and I betcha that'll break old 'beauty queen' out her blues. (to Taffy) Don't you want the world back the way it was? When we all would laugh and cut upon the porch? Them was the days. (to Gladys) When we first moved her Bobby 'n Joe'd walk past the beauty shop every day trying' to "coat" us. They had just signed up for the service. . . We'd make sho' we put Leanne in the middle, that way mens have to talk to either of us before they got to her. That's how I got

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my husband Joe. Leanne thought he was ugly. (Sighs) He is. But he is so sweet. I met him that day, the next week we was married.

TAFFY: Leanne thought Bobby was gonna propose like Joe did fo' he left. He ain't. But he promised while he was away he'd write her . . . She been depressed eva since.

MABEL: What you say, Gladys? Thank of it as usin' the gift God gave you to bring joy and happiness to the world. **Our** world. *(she hands Gladys a pen an piece of paper)* Try this *(dictating to Gladys)* 'I looked at you. You looked good. Gush-dangit. Damn good! And shoot, that was it for me – '

GLADYS: I don't like that. There ain't no flow, no poetry in his speech. Bobby must sound like the Shakespeare of the seas. I must have some kinda style. Like . . . 'I want to leave my fingerprints on your skin, but I suppose this inks will have to suffice. My dear Leanne, I can't wait to see you again. Please kiss the air for me. I know the wind will deliver your lips to my bosom, which aches to hold you again. Yours truly, Bobby.'

TRANSITION

ACTRESS 2: *Now all they had to do was get that letter into the mailman's bag.*
ACTRESS 1: *Luckily Mabel was able to district him while Taffy and Gladys rummaged through this bag, steamed off an overseas stamp to use and tucked their letter into the bottom of his bag.*
ACTRESS 2: *A letter marked TO: Leanne Golden. FROM: Bobby Jenkins*

MABEL: *(overacting badly)* Open it! Open it!

LEANNE: *(crying the truthful kind of tears – undramatic, human – quite different than her tears earlier)* See, I tolja so. He's alive. He's alive.

MABEL: Well, what it say?

LEANNE: I don't know. I can just read the last words . . . Love . . . Bobby.

[Later that Saturday night]

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LEANNE: And when he get back we gone have a big wedding. Daddy gone be so happy. Y'all can be my bridesmaids. I wish I could read it to myself. The only word I can make out is 'love'. Gladys, read my favorite part again. *(stares out the window)*

GLADYS: *(focused on Leanne rather than the letter)* 'I've stared at the slope of your face in my dreams and I remember every curve, every valley of your face from your cheekbones to your lips. I can fall onto those lips like a bed.'

LEANNE: *(turning back to Gladys)* I never thought I'd see him again or hear from him again, but today – Today was like being born again. I feel like a girl again. In love with him like a lil' girl. Help me, Gladys. Help me write back to him.

GLADYS: Write? Back?

LEANNE: He must be scared. All alone over there. Not knowin' when he gone come home. If he gone come home. Please, Gladys. Don't make me beg you.

GLADYS: I'll. Help. *(nods)*

LEANNE: 'Dear Bobby –' *(Scene shifts to pantomime with Leanne dictating while Gladys writes)*

********* SCENE CHANGE *********

MISS MARY: It's nice to see her smilin' 'round here. I'm so glad Bobby decided to write her.

MABEL: *(Mabel laughs then composes herself)* Just happy that Leanne happy. Leanne made it feel like a funeral parlor 'stead of a beauty parlor. Now it's all back. We getting' it all back. Just like we planned.

MISS MARY: Planned? How you plan that? Y'all ain't tellin' me the whole story. So Gladys writin' letters for Leanne?

TAFFY: *(fast-paced)* Gladys pretendin' like she Bobby! *(with a look at Mabel)* Miss Mary was gone find out anyway.

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MISS MARY: Y'all playin' wit' that po' girl heart. What if that maine dead? Whatchall gone do then?

MABEL: It don't matter he ain't dead to her, now! Don't you like yo' beauty shop like this? Happy! Before she got that letter this was like the last stopover fo' Hell. She done cried enough tears to flood the Mississippi Delta thrice over.

MISS MARY: Yo' love don't come back, you don't know how long you'll cry. *(Mabel and Taffy exit as Gladys enters and crosses to go upstairs also)* No so fast, Miss Alabammy!

GLADYS: Yes ma'am?

MISS MARY: Don' you be bein' all nice to me. You too nice. Letting them girls run you like that. Puttin' you all up in they little games. Y'all spinnin' goddamn fairy tales and this real life out there. Real life I tells ya! Whatchoo gone do if he don't come back, huh?

GLADYS: They tolja?

MISS MARY: Yes, they did. A woman heart ain't nothin' to play wit, nah. Believes me, I know. You gone start somethin' you can't finish and what then? What then?

********* SCENE CHANGE **********

LEANNE: *(looking out the window)* I wonder when he gone write me another. And another. And another.

TAFFY: It took him four years to write the first one. Give him some time, damn.

LEANNE: I don't have no more time. What if he dies before he gets back? What if he's dead right now? Oh, no! Bobby is dead! Bobby is DEAD! *(Beat – Leanne bursts into tears and exits)*

MISS MARY: Now, look at what ya'll done done to Leanne!

MABEL: It look like you gone have to write another letter to Leanne. *(Beat)*

GLADYS: Ain't one enough?

TAFFY: Oh, help us, Gladys! Help us out this misery.

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GLADYS: Another letter? I can't lie like that again. I'm already writing back letters to him as her. I'm lyin' thisaway and thataway. I'm lyin' all over the place.

MABEL: Don't get to feelin' all guilty on us, church girl. Is a lie a lie if it's a good lie? 'Sides, when you go to church tomorrow, repent! All yo' sins'll be washed away.

GLADYS: But I got my own work to do. My own stories to tell. I'm tired of tellin' lies.

TAFFY: Please! PLEASE!

MABEL: One more tale to end our HELL –

GLADYS: All right! All right! I'll do it if y'all just hush. Just let me have peace. *(the girls exit and alone on stage, Gladys begins to write)* 'Dear Leanne – ' I was walkin' down the street in Paris. I was struck by how it smelled. There are lavender gardens here. It smells like purple and promise, baby breath and longing. It smells of you. . . ' *(to herself)* I wish she loved me like she loves you. (Beat) There, I said it. I can't believe it. I finally said it . . I feel so ashamed. I ain't supposed to feel this way. I shouldn't feel like this, like – God gone be mad at me.

***** SCENE CHANGE *******

LEANNE: Read it to me again.

GLADYS AND LEANNE: 'You ever smelled lavender, love. It smells of purple and promise, baby breath and longing. It smells of you.'

GLADYS: Well, don't you know it by heart.

LEANNE: Well, it's my favorite part. Oh, he loves me. He loves me so!! When this crazy world gone let my maine come home. Let him come home to me. I could wait on my maine forever.

GLADYS: He wouldn't wait on you forever.

LEANNE: You don't know him. Bobby is a gentlemen.

GLADYS: No. He ain't. He waited too long to write ya . . . if you ask me. Four years? *(Beat)* Leanne . . . I wanna tell you something!

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LEANNE: I wanna tell you something! I wanna propose to Bobby. *(silence)*

GLADYS: Leanne, are you sure you love him? I can't . . . can't write this letter. You don't love him. You don't even know him. Who the hell is Bobby?

LEANNE: He exists right here *(pointing to her chest)*

GLADYS: Nooo! HE exists in there *(pointing to Leanne's head)* He ain't here, Leanne! You deserve someone who'll be there for you. Right here. Right now. Bobby ain't that kind of man.

LEANNE: These letters tell a different story.

GLADYS: Those letters might be a lie! WHY?! Why you love him sooo much?

LEANNE: He the first man that done made me feel . . . feel like God inside. You ever felt that, Gladys? . . . I would wait on that feeling again forever . . . help me propose to my man. *(Gladys is defeated an submits. She takes out her typewriter)* 'Dear Bobby, Will you marry me? Love, Leanne'

GLADYS: *(quickly types. Silence)* That it? *(Gladys stands and opens her mouth. She tries to speak, but before she can profess her heart a radio broadcast breaks the silence)*

RADIO: We interrupt your regular radio program for a special message from the President of the United States of America, Harry S. Truman. 'On this day, August 15th, Japan has surrendered. The final Axis ally has fallen. . . America has won her blessed fight on this day. Today war will be no more . . .. '

GLADYS: *(pulls out a letter from her dresser and holds it out to Leanne)* I'm sorry I never gave this to you before. This the last one. *(Beat)* Ain't you gone open it? *(Gladys dictates the letter without it being opened)* 'Dear Leanne, I've never felt this way about someone. I've tried and tried to stop thinking of you. I never knew somethin' so bad could feel so good. I love sleepin' besides you. You are an angel to me. I live for Saturday nights, Leanne. But the most god-awful hour of my existence is when Saturday night roll into Sunday morning. In those wee hours of dawn I repent my heart's sin, for everything I yearn for, I know

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God will never let me win' *(silence – Leanne snatches the paper from Gladys's hands and tries to read the last words.)*

LEANNE: 'Love, Gl – Gla – a / dys. *(Leanne backs away from Gladys)* So . . you . . you Bobby? You lied to me!

GLADYS: I meant every word.

LEANNE: Not like that! I am not that way. You think I'm that way?

GLADYS: I just wanted to make you feel like God inside.

LEANNE: You will never make me feel like that. You are nasty! Sick! Here I thought you was a church goin' girl! *(Leanne exits in tears)*

GLADYS: But I have repented. I repent every day. I repent. *(silent tears slide down Gladys' face)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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